

In the April 19 release *Do Aur Do Pyaar*, a romantic comedy about two adulterous couples, Pratik Gandhi will be seen alongside Vidya Balan

Once his career in Gujarati cinema took off with films like *Bey Yaar*, *Wrong Side Raju*, *Love Ni Bhavai* and *Ventilator*, Pratik put in his papers.

Embracing Hindi mainstream cinema doesn't mean he's changed. He still hasn't signed onto a talent management firm, instead turning to his actor-wife Bhamini Oza, his brother Punit, a graphic designer and artist, and his friend, publicist and business consultant Kajal Gadhia, for feedback on scripts. His own instinct matters most. "I don't get into [box office] mathematics to make my choice," he says. "We are in the business of experiments, and they have to be done honestly."

Pratik doesn't want to be boxed in. That's what makes his act in *Madgaon Express* particularly impressive. Essaying the shyest of three friends, Pratik plays on the vulnerabilities of Pinku and often makes himself the butt of a joke to build a connection with the audience. The actor admits it's "the loudest version of comedy" he's done so far and yet, in his hands, it's understated. His key request to director Kunal Kemmu was that he won't stoop to the clichéd trope of using a sing-song Gujarati accent to draw laughs. Says Pratik, "All Gujaratis don't talk like that. We don't have *khakhra* and *dhokla* on our dining table every day." Gujarati, he says, should sound as seamless as Punjabi does in Hindi films.

With *Do Aur Do Pyaar*, he continues on the comic route, but he assures audiences will discover a different Pratik in the process. "It makes you laugh; at the same time; it makes you sad," he says. The film focuses on a married couple (Pratik and Balan) contending with the seven-year itch. "Nobody knows why it's not working," he says. "In their own minds, they have their reasons [for cheating] and are right. I feel nothing is more complex than love, and the film explores different aspects of it and makes the characters human."

Infusing humanity into his characters is an eternal quest and it's what Pratik is presently doing with *Gandhi* too, having wrapped up 40 per cent of the show already. It's a role that he has been playing on stage for eight years and his admiration for the leader only grows. The show, for him, is particularly relevant. "There's a generation that's understanding him very weirdly and differently, and [have] almost made him frivolous," he says. "The world needs Gandhi at this time more than any other." ■

–Suhani Singh



After eight years of pitching scripts **JAI MEHTA** makes his solo directorial debut with Disney+ Hotstar's *Lootere*



work calendar was crammed, Jai came on board to direct and ended up chipping in with the writing as well. "I didn't expect making this show would be as hard as it was," he says. "Covid-19 outbreak, weather hindrances, everything that could go wrong, went wrong." Hansal ended up being the showrunner and also did the clap for the first scene shot.

Battling adversity is by now second nature to Jai given he is his father's child. "If the journey is tough, only something good will come out of it," is one of the maxims he swears by. From Hansal, he's learnt the art of "persistence", putting faith in one's collaborators and, most significantly, adapting the story to the resources at one's disposal. "A film never fails, the only thing that does is budget," he says.

But there's a flip side to being a filmmaker's son, he says. In his case, it was "being infantilised", which he feels "is far worse than a nepotistic problem. No one will take you seriously because you look too young." After *Lootere*, that perception is likely to be put to rest. Jai's solo film voyage has begun. ■

–Suhani Singh